

EARLY TO RISE

7 Things That Can Make a Difference to **YOUR LIFE...**

And Perhaps, the World

Another Successful Chronicle by Dr. Vishal K Gupta



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Dr. Vishal K Gupta

Business Professor at the University of Alabama (United States)

(www.drvgupta.com)

Published by:

B Ed Admission

G-36, Outer Circle, G-Block, Connaught Place, New Delhi – 110001 India

Ph: 8800610909 & 8800599090

W: www.bedadmission.net

E: info@bedadmission.net

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“To my parents, who taught me a lot about life and work”

Dr. Vishal K Gupta

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**“Success is
99% Perspiration
and
1% Inspiration”**

Preface

There is no dearth of ambition in the world. No matter where you are in the world, you will find yourself surrounded by ambitious people. Indeed, ambition is one human quality that may be hard-wired into all of us. References to ambition can be found in the foundational texts of all major world religions as well as classics from ancient civilizations. Of course, ambition does not always manifest similarly in all cultures and even people within the same culture often experience ambition in different ways. Men and women- many believe- express ambition differently; so do the Japanese, Indians, and the Americans, the poor and the well-to-do.

The interesting thing about humans is not that we are ambitious, but it is that so few of actualize our ambitions. Research from around the world reveals that a large proportion of people around us are dissatisfied with their career and/or life, feeling they should have accomplished way more than they did. It is tempting to think that this is a 'talent problem', as in perhaps one's ambition far exceeds the talent s/he has. Management experts and social scientists often point to people's innate gifts and natural talents to explain their work performance and success. I am sure you have heard phrases such as "She's such a natural at managing people" or "He's brilliant at designing things." These talent-based explanations profoundly influence how we think about what allows people to achieve their ambitions and succeed. Yet, the truth is that talent is over-rated. For most people, becoming successful, making a difference to the world, and achieving their ambitions is not a result of the qualities they were born with, but of the behaviors and actions that made up their life.

As a business professor, I am fortunate to have the time, skills, and interest in reading about and meeting with some of the most successful people in the world. To make sense of what distinguished the best from the rest, I organized my thoughts into seven simple lessons that seem to have universal appeal. Whether I was teaching in the US or in India, visiting with students in Portugal or Bahrain, whenever I shared the seven lessons, I found my audiences reacting favorably. In their feedback to me, students would often share that what they appreciated most was that the simple things I talked about seemed to apply across different walks of life. I also found that the seven lessons I focused on echoed, in one form or another, in the stories of many guest speakers I invited to visit with my students, ranging from top cops to corporate leaders to political stalwarts. These guests, who generously shared their time and wisdom with students, recounted their own experiences: How they were always seeking new opportunities, how they learned to practice humility, or how starting the day early helped them navigate through the challenges and tribulations of an otherwise stressful life and career. As I shared what I was learning with the corporate executives and leaders who I met in the course of my work, I found that they too wanted to learn what I had to say. They wanted to know how these lessons helped people become successful, and in the process, make a positive difference in the world.

Oh, and one more thing: You will find that in discussing my ideas throughout the book, I use examples from around the world. My goal is to use illustrative examples, regardless of whether they are from the United States, China, Europe, or anywhere else in the world. Successful people whose habits and qualities are worth

emulating can be found in every country, so I see little reason to restrict my examples to one or another country. Given the global world we live in, it seems fitting that our books present examples from around the world. During my talks, I found students to be receptive to such a global approach, and so I follow it in this book.

Writing this book allowed me to organize, in a succinct manner, various talks, workshops, and lectures I had done in the last few years. Each chapter here attempts to illustrate and contextualize the individual lessons by relating them to extraordinary humans who have been an inspiration to countless others around the world. At the end, I share with you a talk I gave that started me on the path of this book. The talk summarized the ideas I discuss in length in this book, but it also gave me an opportunity to see how people responded to my ideas. Initially, I was somewhat nervous about finding a receptive audience for my unconventional message. I was therefore pleasantly surprised when people enthusiastically responded to my talks, with many later coming up to me to discuss how they will try to follow the things I brought up. It was then that the idea for this book was born. I hope you enjoy reading this book as much as I enjoyed thinking about it and writing it.

Chapter One

Start the Day Fresh and Early



It is well to be up before daybreak, for such habits contribute to health, wealth, and wisdom.

Aristotle

The borough of Brooklyn is an unlikely place to start our journey. Brooklyn is the most populous borough of New York City (financial capital of the U.S.), but with both the median and mean income below national average. The US Census Bureau estimates that a quarter of Brooklyn's residents to be below the poverty line. A mix of different ethnicities live here, from Jewish Americans to Irish immigrants. Howard Schultz, founder and former chief executive of coffee giant Starbucks, is one of the most successful people to come from Brooklyn. The son of a down-on-his-luck truck driver father and an ambitious mother, Schultz used an athletic scholarship to pay through college and later worked with Xerox as a sales representative. Soon, Schultz transitioned to selling coffee makers, and subsequently founded the coffee retailer later christened Starbucks. Schultz is now ranked among the richest people in America by the Forbes magazine, but even more importantly, he is widely credited with pioneering the coffee culture in the country. The coffee chain Schultz founded has a global footprint, and many parts of the world equate Starbucks with quality coffee.

How does Schultz manage the busy workload that comes with such success? Schultz himself credits his incredible ability to manage his time efficiently to his habit of waking up at 4.30 AM every morning, starting his day fresh and early. He begins by working out and walking his dogs, and by 5.45AM, it's time for coffee with his wife. Starting his day early enables Schultz to get about a two-hour head-start over more than 80% of his fellow Americans who wake up after 5.30AM and 50% of his compatriots as they wake up after 6.30AM. Indeed, from Japan to Venezuela to Egypt, Schultz wakes up earlier than most of the world. A 2015 study of waking

habits of 941,300 people in 50 countries reveals that Schultz is out of bed sooner than most people in the world as the average person in the world wakes up between 7 and 8AM.

Notably, Schultz is not alone in his affinity for waking up early. So does fellow Brooklyn native and CEO of Xerox (Schultz' first employer) Ursula Burns who starts her day at 5.15AM. PepsiCo CEO Indra Nooyi and Virgin founder Richard Branson also known to prefer an early morning start (4AM and 4.45AM, respectively). Mary Barra, CEO of auto giant General Motors, is in the office by 6AM, and Jeff Immelt of GE starts his day with working out at 5.30AM. Early mornings are not reserved solely for business executives. Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi is up before the crack of dawn at 5AM, getting a head-start on the day. Former US first lady Michelle Obama works out at 4.30AM, getting some personal time much before the rest of world (and her kids) rolls out of bed.

Why does it help to be an early riser? Why is it that the 'early bird get the worm', as a popular saying suggests? (Germans too have a similar saying: *Morgenstund hat Gold im Mund*, roughly translated as 'the early morning has gold in its mouth'). For one, consistently rising up early helps bring discipline and structure to one's life. It also opens up more hours in the day in which to get things done. Waking up early provides one with a few hours of calm in which one think and act without being constantly interrupted by emails, social conversation, and other demands on one's time. Early morning is also a good time to exercise, which can boost fitness and mood, bringing renewed energy on the job at hand. Tim Cook uses the morning hours to get his workout and finish up on emails before he gets bogged

down with strategic and operational responsibilities of managing the sprawling Apple empire.

It is tempting to believe that one can substitute getting up early with going to bed late. In other words, early-to-rise can be readily replaced by late-to-bed, with little loss in value. Unfortunately, staying up late is not only not as healthy as waking up early, it is actually unhealthy. Why may this be the case? To answer this question we need to look back at Albert Einstein's work. Artificial light- as is the case with Einstein's invention of the light bulb- allows us to work even when it is dark outside, and is a relatively recent phenomenon in human history. The human body has been conditioned, over centuries, to work in daylight and rest at night when it is dark outside. While indoor lighting permits us to unshackle ourselves from the constraints of daylight, it is a fact that human body does not react well to working at night. Research has shown that those who work at nights for long periods of time develop a range of serious diseases from Type 2 diabetes to cancer to coronary heart disease. It was always assumed that our body clock would adapt to working at night, but as Britain's leading sleep expert, Prof. Russell Foster, from Oxford University points out, "the really extraordinary finding across a whole range of different studies, is that you don't adapt" to working the night shift.

Is it possible to both go to bed late and wake up early? You often hear media reports about people who follow such a lifestyle, getting only about 4-5 hours of sleep every night. The sleeping habits of famous people, such as business executives Donald Trump and Martha Stewart and political luminaries like Margaret Thatcher and Jawaharlal Nehru, who are known to sleep merely around four hours

daily, is covered extensively in popular press. “From Mozart to Obama: The Rich and Famous Make Do With Very Little Sleep” runs a newspaper headline extolling the virtues of sleeping little, reinforcing the myth that one can function well on four hours of sleep. According to a recent Gallup poll, 40% of all Americans are sleep deprived, clocking much less than the recommended minimum of about seven hours sleep per night.

However, sleep deprivation is not just an American problem; it is a global concern. From Japan to the United Kingdom, more than half of the people surveyed in every country reported not getting sufficient sleep on weeknights. Arianna Huffington, co-founder and editor-in-chief of the Huffington Post, terms this the ‘sleep deprivation crisis’, where society celebrates those who operate on little sleep. Consider a recent magazine advertisement for the new head of the Indian state of Uttar Pradesh, which noted that the democratically-elected leader has “conquered sleep”, so that he no longer needs to sleep more than 3-4 hours per night. Such celebration of less sleep is rooted in cultural dismissal of sleep as wasted time, which can undermine our health, decision-making ability, and work and personal lives.

How much sleep one needs will obviously vary from person to person, but scientists believe that people generally need six to nine hours of sleep every night. Unfortunately, most people underestimate the amount of sleep they need, leading to the sleep deprivation crisis that Huffington discusses in her 2016 book. It is possible to work on less sleep for a short time, but those who sleep less on a regular basis will find themselves unable to think clearly and function to their full potential. Too

much sleep takes away valuable time from the day; too little sleep can have adverse consequences for our well-being, work outcomes, and happiness.

Schultz, Burns, Modi, and others we discussed here all understand that waking up early brings much-needed routine to your life and work, and expands the number of working hours in the day. However, waking up early is not the same as being sleep deprived. The key is to wake up early, without getting less sleep than the body needs (by going to bed early). Those who fail to get enough sleep before getting an early start will find themselves less, not more, productive. Rising early is a simple act that can give us a positive push to starting the day. If you want to make a difference in your life, and perhaps the world, it is easy to get started- Just wake up early.

Chapter Two

Always Speak Positively



We cannot control the way people interpret our ideas or thoughts, but we can control the words and tones we choose to convey them. Never underestimate the power of a single word, and never recklessly throw around words.

Suzy Kassem

You may have heard the song, “Its only words. And words are all I have.” While this is a romantic song, the message of its opening lines is applicable much more broadly. Indeed, the power of words is universal and applies across all human interactions. The words we use to talk about ourselves and others shape how people perceive us. Words, when used carelessly, can be damaging and hurtful, but when used carefully, words can be helpful and constructive. But what is not as well understood is that the words we use can also make or break us as our image and reputation are built or destroyed by how we speak about others.

An old proverb says that “The words of the reckless pierce like swords, but the tongue of the wise brings healing.” What are these ‘reckless words’? They are poisonous darts many of us throw (often without much thought) at people behind their back or in the heat of an argument or in the flow of interpersonal humor. Whether in schools or colleges, or in family or in the workplace, I am sure everyone can recall toxic words directed at them or someone else. These words can pierce the heart like a poisonous dagger, yet the speaker may not even have the intention of hurting the other person. They were used just because!

Social places- like schools and the family- are fertile grounds for gossip and ideal chatter. Much of this chatter tends to be negative in tone, meant to disparage or belittle others. It is tempting to engage in such negative conversation, especially when one is around people who encourage us to be caustic in expressing our views. People often contend they are simply expressing themselves candidly when they are being critical of someone (‘I speak from my heart’, is their logic). Yet, these same

people tend to be quite sensitive to others using critical or negative words about them.

Dr. Masaru Emoto is a Japanese scientist who describes an interesting series of experiments in his book *The Hidden Messages in Water* (a New York Times bestseller). In the experiments, Emoto poured pure water into vials labeled with either negative phrases or positive phrases, and then froze the water. Emoto's findings were stunning: Water in vials with positive phrases on them froze to produce gleaming, perfectly hexagonal crystals, while water in vials with negative phrases yielded gray, misshapen clumps. Emoto details his experiment in his best-selling book, where you can also see before and after photographs of the crystals formed when pure water is frozen under positive and negative conditions.

A famous historical figure who could have benefited tremendously from learning about Emoto's findings was General George Patton, the charismatic and feared commander of the US Army in Europe during World War II. Widely considered to be one of the heroes of the US victory in the last world war, Patton was also notorious for his ill-tempered bursts. Although he won many difficult battles fighting against high odds, Patton found his career impeded and reputation damaged as former subordinates were promoted to superior positions. Reason? His inability to effectively monitor the words coming out of mouth. He famously declared a sick soldier to be a "goddamned coward", publicly described Russians as "drunk [and] with no regard for human life", and was frequently quoted in the press for his controversial (and sarcastic) statements. A historian concluded that "Patton was among the greatest generals of the war", but "arrogant, publicity-seeking, and

personally flawed.” While Patton’s success in the battlefield is undeniable, his legacy has been irreparably tainted by his lack of tongue control.

Uber’s CEO Travis Kalanick is a contemporary business leader who seems to have inherited Patton’s loose and caustic speech. Founder of a successful ridesharing company (more on it later), Kalanick has been at the receiving end of public criticism over his unprofessional utterances, from unsavory remarks about women to demeaning rants directed at drivers. Unfortunately, for Kalanick (and many others, such as famed Hollywood actor and director Mel Gibson), we live in the age of social media when comments you make are recorded and quickly broadcasted to a worldwide audience. At the time of this writing, Kalanick had rendered a public apology for his many verbal transgressions and promised to reform himself (my advice to Kalanick: Make it a point of never saying negative things about others).

One famed celebrity who has mastered the art of positive speaking is the Indian superstar Amitabh Bachchan. With over 150 films to his credit (many of them blockbusters), Bachchan is widely considered to be the most successful film star ever. Born in 1942, Bachchan is 75 now, yet he frequently ranks among the top cinema stars annually, both in popular polls and in critics’ choice. Despite his unparalleled success, Bachchan is a journalist’s nightmare, particularly for those looking for trash talk to headline tabloids and sell copies (or attract eyeballs). Early in his career, Bachchan often found himself being coaxed by journalists to bad-mouth rivals (some still try to get him to speak negatively about other public figures), but no one ever succeeded in getting him to criticize or trash anyone. Bachchan has now spent almost 50 years in the film world, under the glaring lights of the press and

public, but one would be hard-pressed to find instances where he spoke negatively about someone or even one individual who can reliably claim to have heard Bachchan disparage another person.

Organizations, whether family or workplace, are full of gossiping and small talk where it is tempting to say negative things about others. When caught speaking negatively or disparagingly about someone, many claim they speak from the heart (their excuse: I say things as they are, and I do not sugarcoat). However, the heart and mind can be filled with positive thoughts and trash talk about anyone should be avoided as much as possible. Remember the 2014 hack of Sony CEO's emails? The kind of insensitive negative comments made in those emails were so damaging to then-CEO Amy Pascale's reputation (as well as many others whose emails were also hacked) that she had to resign within months of the emails becoming public. I have often wondered if Pascale ever regrets having made those negative statements in her emails. I bet she never thought those emails would ever come into the public domain. It may be easy to trash talk about others and more difficult to speak positively, but it is certainly worthwhile to try inculcating this very rare quality. If you want to make a difference, always focus on speaking positively.

Chapter Three

Find a Good Guide



A lot of people have gone further than they thought they could because someone else thought they could.
Unknown

The Merriam-Webster Dictionary defines a 'mentor' as a trusted guide or counselor and mentorship as the guidance provided by an experienced person. A mentor can be a parent, a professor, a boss in the workplace, or anyone else who is relatively senior to you in an organization. There are two parties in a mentoring relationship: mentor and protégé. An ideal mentoring relationship is one where both parties benefit from working with each other.

Mentorship is not a till-death-do-us-part deal (for either parties); instead, one should seek a mentor suitable at particular stages of life. Consider tennis champion Novak Djokovic of Serbia. This player was ranked No. 2 in the world at the time of this writing, but had recently found himself in a slump after he had already made his mark by winning four straight majors. He then read former tennis great Andre Agassi's autobiography 'Open', reached out to him for guidance, and enlisted him as his coach. Djokovic had earlier been a protégé of Boris Becker, another retired grand slam winner. Similarly, before Steve Jobs became a business legend, he was a brash young man with little direction, focus, or knowledge. His life was transformed for the better when he got access to outstanding mentors like Steve Wozniak (co-founder of Apple) and Mike Markula (Apple's first outside investor) to teach him the ropes of business and technology.

Mentors provide two key benefits: one, mentors are a competent source of technical and commercial knowledge; and second, mentors provide professional and socioemotional support. Sometimes a single mentor can serve both roles, and sometimes you need different mentors that excel in specific areas. A good mentor can make a tremendous difference between success and failure in one's career.

Consider the case of Jamie Dimon, former chief executive of JP Morgan Chase. Dimon was a freshly minted MBA from the prestigious Harvard Business School in 1982, when he crossed paths with Sandy Weill who was already a minor legend on Wall Street (Weill's wife was already friends with Dimon's mother). For the next 16 years, Weill and Dimon worked side-by-side, with the latter serving as 'junior partner' under Weill's tutelage. During this time, they built a financial behemoth, culminating in a market-shaking deal with the merger of Travelor's Group and Citicorp. A 1995 New York Times article noted that "Weill's protégé is on the move", publishing a picture showing Dimon in the forefront with Weill standing distantly behind like a 'proud father' enjoying his offspring's success.

If mentors are so useful, and companies of myriad shapes and sizes profess a corporate commitment to encourage mentorship, why is good mentoring so rare? I believe there are three reasons why most people do not have helpful mentors to guide them: First, the myth of the self-made man; second, unwillingness to learn from others; and third, excessive suspicion of others' motives. Let me briefly explain each of the issues. Many societies have tales and myths that celebrate those who seem to lift themselves by their own bootstrap (e.g., Horatio Alger stories in the US). While the appeal of these stories lies in that they allow, and even pull, people in the direction they want to go, they also convey the misimpression that one does not need others to improve their station in life. Further, there is an incomprehensible sense among many people that they do not need to learn anything from others. Unfortunately, at least for people who think along such lines, nothing could be further from truth. The fact of life is that there is much to be learned from the experiences

and insights of others. Instead of refusing to learn from others, we should seek those who are willing to share their learning with us. Finally, unreasonable suspicion of others makes it difficult to seek and trust advice we receive. We tend to forget that suspicion and trust are essential human characteristics that need to be balanced. Both excessive suspicion and blind trust can be harmful, so that the best approach is to strike a balance between suspecting others and trusting them.

Mentoring is useful not just for those who want to be successful or are on their way up, but also for those who may be at the pinnacle of success. Consider Bill Gates, founder of Microsoft and at one time the richest person in the world. Gates first met Warren Buffet in 1991. At the time, Microsoft was still in its 11th year, while Buffet was already well known as a highly successful investor. Bill had not been much interested in meeting with Buffet: “He just buys and sells pieces of paper. That’s not real value added. I don’t think we’d have much in common”. Bill was soon to realize how wrong he had been. Warren was highly interested in what Bill was doing, asking probing questions, forcing Bill to think about his business in ways he had never done before. Buffet helped Bill learn how to deal with tremendous success, not take himself too seriously, and nurture deep and careful friendships. To this day, Bill considers Warren to be like a father figure, someone he can turn to when he needs advice and counsel. (A side note: Bill serves on the board of Buffet’s Berkshire Hathaway, helping Buffet learn about technology, a strong suite of Bill’s).

A famous saying tells us that “no man is an island”. Humans do not thrive when they are isolated from others. No matter what station of life it is, a good mentor

can help you move ahead. Spend some time and energy finding good mentors. And, never forget to be a helpful mentor for those coming behind you.

Chapter Four

Humility is the Best Policy



As salt is needed for all kinds of food, so humility is needed for all kinds of virtues.

St. Isaac, the Syrian

Let's begin this chapter with a brief thought experiment: Think of a few people you believe are regarded as truly great figures in history. When I think of great historical personalities, the names that immediately come to my mind are Nelson Mandela, Gandhi, and Mother Teresa. I suspect your list of admirable historical figures is along similar lines. What do you think these people, and almost all others who we tend to admire, have in common? It may come as a surprise to many that the key factor which characterizes admirable personalities is that they are seen as humble. Even though we may live in a narcissistic age, it is not hubris, but humility that gets others to respect you.

If humility is the 'secret ingredient of success' as some have noted, one would expect success and humility to go hand in hand. Unfortunately, this is not the case. Success tends to breed hubris and erodes humility, making it increasingly difficult for people to behave humbly as they become more successful. For this reason, successful people need to deliberately and intentionally practice humility. They need to remember that humility is attractive and draws in other people (think: the Dalai Lama). Conversely, hubris is repulsive and makes people dislike, or even hate, you (think: Adolf Hitler). It would be no exaggeration to say that, across cultures, humility is appreciated much more than hubris. People like others who are humble about their successes, and feel less threatened by their achievements. Boastful, arrogant behaviors do not appeal to most people, often inducing strong social disapprovals.

Whether one is successful or not, humility is not something you are naturally born with. Instead, humility is learned so that at any stage in life, we can learn to be humble and get better at showing humility through repeated practice. Some confuse

humility with lack of self-confidence. It is however a mistake to believe that hubris reflects high self-confidence and humility is indicative of low self-confidence. In fact, humility works even better for confident people as long as they are able to resist hubris and arrogance. Consider Larry Ellison, the founder CEO of Oracle and one of the richest people in the world. Can you guess what they say is the biggest difference between God and Ellison? The answer: God doesn't think He's Larry Ellison. (I promise you I didn't make up this stuff. Check out the title of Mike Wilson's book about Ellison, and see for yourself). While there is no doubt that Ellison is a successful entrepreneur who worked his way to the upper echelons of the global software industry, it is well known that Ellison and humility do not go in the same sentence. The lack of humility may not have stopped Ellison from being successful, it did prevent him from becoming well-respected. If Ellison were to come across as humble (as is the case with the next high profile entrepreneur we profile below), he would have undoubtedly elicited admiration and respect from others.

Many years ago when I lived in Omaha (Nebraska), I had the privilege of joining in the annual gala that is Berkshire Hathaway's annual meeting. If you have never been to a Berkshire Hathaway annual meeting, you should definitely try to go to one as it is a memorable event for most attendees. A lot of rich and famous people were there, including Bill Gates, the well-known CEO of Microsoft. But the center of attraction at Berkshire Hathaway's annual meeting is Warren Buffet. It is Buffett's legend that attracts thousands of people from around the world to a small town in the middle of nowhere once a year. A large part of the Buffett charm comes from the humility he exudes in his everyday behaviors. He still lives in the small

house he bought more than 50 years ago, drives a cheap car, dresses simply, and talks in a down-to-earth tone you would normally associate with your neighborhood retirees. So well known is Buffett's humility that many consider him to be the 'most humble rich man the world has ever witnessed'.

The word humility is rooted in the Latin word — '*humus*' meaning — 'earth' or — 'ground', and from the Latin word — '*humilis*' meaning — 'on the ground'. Colloquialisms like — 'down- to-earth' and — 'having a grounded view' reflect humility's lexical origin. Psychologists generally regard humility as a — 'temperance virtue' that guards against excess (i.e., inflated estimate of one's own knowledge and abilities) and have held up humility as a historically revered characteristic and a multifaceted strength. Notably, humility is a foundational principle in most world religions, which speaks to the universal and enduring appeal of this quality. Therefore, I say, if you want to make a difference in the world, learn to be humble.



Chapter Five

Resilience Rocks!



Tough times don't last; tough people do

Chanakya

After several humiliating political defeats in the early 1960s, then-lawyer Richard Nixon (later to become the 37th president of the US) decorated his office with a copper plaque titled 'Lincoln's Failures'. Abraham Lincoln, widely considered among the most iconic American presidents so far, was famous for having a long string of failures behind him- he failed at business and lost several political races before finally being elected president. Lincoln's story is a classic tale of resilience, the ability to persevere in the face of setbacks. What Lincoln's life teaches us (as it did Nixon) is that failures and stumbles are part and parcel of professional life, and one needs oodles of resilience to persist in the face of adversity. Life is rarely full of only roses for anyone, and so how one deals with adversity is key to success at work and satisfaction in life.

Interestingly, most people consider themselves to be fairly resilient. But the truth is that most of us are not psychologically or emotionally equipped to handle adversity, which means that instead of facing problems and challenges confidently, we tend to feel helpless and give up. The good news is that resilience is not a genetically determined trait nor are there genetic constraints on how resilient one can be. Resilience instead is like a muscle. With practice, you can strengthen your resilience and profoundly change how you handle setbacks. Some of us may be born into circumstances that help forge resilience early, but most of us need to actively learn and practice how to handle challenges without shrinking. Resilience is certainly not an either/or trait; instead, it is a continuum and no matter where you fall on that continuum today, you can work on increasing your reserves of resilience, so

you can approach even most unsurmountable problems with enthusiasm and determination.

American psychologist Martin Seligman (fondly called the Father of Positive Psychology) spent decades studying how people deal with failures. His research revealed that people who do not give up easily tend to view setbacks as changeable (“I can do something about it”), local (“not everything in life is bad, but just this one situation”), and temporary (“it can go away”). People who see problems as unchangeable, permanent, and pervasive become pessimistic and lose hope for better outcomes. Such people take even minor events seriously, blow them up in their heads, run through them over and over, and drive themselves crazy worrying and ruminating.

The difference between Lincoln and those who did not persevere through setbacks is largely perception: Is the failure or setback seen as debilitating or an opportunity to learn? Frame adversity as a learning opportunity and one becomes more flexible and able to deal well with it, learn from it and grow. Think of adversity as a threat, and it seems like an enduring problem that cannot be dealt with. Look at Jack Ma, the founder of Chinese giant Alibaba. His list of failures include rejection for a job at KFC-China, and for employment with the local police force, and for admission to Harvard. By his own admission, he failed several times during his school and college days. Ma likes to compare himself to Forrest Gump (from the hit Hollywood film) in that both never give up even when the odds are stacked against them.

Whether it is Lincoln or Jack Ma, resilience is key to their success. While some are fortunate to be quite resilient because of the circumstances of their upbringing, others need to develop their resilience. Because resilience is not immutable, it can be strengthen and reinforced with deliberate effort. The message here is clear: If you want to make a difference to the world, work on your resilience and not be discouraged by failure.

Chapter Six

Follow Your Passion



The best advice I could give anyone is to spend time working on what you are passionate in life.

J. K. Rowling

The word 'passion' often feels like a buzzword as it's thrown around quite liberally. We are told it pays to be passionate in our jobs. The sad truth, however, is that, across cultures, most people report hating their jobs. They are doing it only because of the paycheck at the end of the month. Some estimate that in the US about two-thirds of the workforce could care less about their job. Data from other countries paints an equally dismal picture, with comparable figures at 55% in India, 46% in Britain, and 34% in Germany expressing dislike for their jobs.

Yet, as people like the Virgin Atlantic founder Richard Branson contend, "you spend 80% of your adult life working, so why not do something you enjoy." Passion has long been understood as doing something you enjoy. Indeed, finding a job that you love doing is common advice for ages. Confucius famously declared that "choose a job you love, and you will never have to work a day in your life." Buffett's advice is similar: Get a job you love.

But, I think, an equally relevant aspect of passion, albeit one that is not usually discussed, is to love what you do. As Steve Jobs argued "the only way to do great work is to love what you do." Travis Kalanick, the founder of Uber, didn't start the ride-sharing service because he loved cars or transportation or logistics. He started it because he was upset he couldn't get a cab in San Francisco. A random brainstorming session one night with friends turned that frustration into a business idea. And then, as Kalanick got more and more involved with the company, he realized that he loved the idea as it had the kind of growth potential he had long been searching for. Uber, as most everyone knows, is now a multi-billion dollar company with operations in more than 50 countries around the world.

It is tempting to think that just someone is successful at what s/he does, they will fall in love with it. While being successful at something does increase the odds of falling in love with it, this is not always the case. Steve Wozniak, for example, was a co-founder of Apple, who quit the company to become a school teacher because he no longer felt passionate enough about what he had been doing.

A common mistake people make is to assume that loving their work means they need to like every minute of it. Nothing could be further from reality. I suspect there is rarely a person in the world who loves his or her work every minute of the day. What matters is if, on the whole, love your work much more often than you don't. Or as Jobs explained in his Stanford Commencement speech, "for the past 33 years, I have looked in the mirror and asked myself: If today were the last day of my life, would I want to do what I am about to do today? And whenever the answer has been 'no' for too many days in a row, I know I need to change something." In other words, it's okay if you don't love what you do (or do what you love) all the time. In fact, it is to be expected that not every aspect of your work will stir your passions. So, you need to think above what you love and what you do at general, more aggregate, level.

Remember Nadia Comaneci? A Romanian, she was the first woman (in 1976) to score a perfect 10 in an Olympics gymnastics event. Fast forward to today, more than 30 years later, an American Simon Biles is the reigning queen of women's gymnastics. And, what do you think Comaneci and Biles have in common? Their love for gymnastics, or as Comaneci likes to say, their passion for what they do. In effect, if you want to make a difference, be passionate about what you do.

Chapter Seven

Pursue New Opportunities Proactively



The ladder of success is best climbed by stepping on the rungs of an opportunity.

Ayn Rand

The election of Donald Trump to the presidency of the United States caught most people by surprise. Beating overwhelming odds, Trump managed to ascend to the highest elected office in the land. While Trump had long expressed an interest in politics, he had never ran for public office before. So, how did he get here? The answer is quite simple: his relentless pursuit of new opportunities. Donald was born in an upper middle-class family dealing in real estate. He started his career with the family business, making his mark through aggressive pursuit of high-visibility deals. With time, he expanded into casinos, bought a football team, released a part-memoir part-advice book that became a best seller, and acquired the Miss Universe pageants. He also hosted TV and radio shows, got involved with professional wrestling, associated his name with numerous business enterprises, and even appeared in films. Over the years, Trump became a master at recognizing new opportunities, pushing himself in ever new areas. Trump is what you may call an 'opportunity seeker', someone who is open to new opportunities all the time.

There is a large academic literature on the benefits of pursuing new opportunities. Most people will tell you that they are always open to novel opportunities. The truth, however, is very different. The sad fact is that most people either do not try to find new opportunities or decline opportunities that come their way. Why may this be the case? To quote Edison, "opportunity is missed by most people because it is dressed in overalls and looks like work". Not only do opportunities look like work, they actually entail considerable work in pursuing them. New opportunities seldom come labeled as sure-shot tickets to success; instead, they come in the form of additional work. To take on a new opportunity means to

agree to more work. Consider that in the 1980s, Trump had his plate full with real-estate commitments. Yet, he accepted a book offer, which turned out to be one of the best decisions he made. Trump partnered with a professional writer (Tony Schwartz, credited on the book cover), outsourcing much of the writing to him. While Trump may not have actually written much of the book himself, his willingness to consider the book opportunity set him apart from other business moguls at the time.

Virgin founder Richard Branson subscribes to the idea that “if someone offers you an amazing opportunity and you’re not sure you can do it, say yes- and learn how to do it later.” Of course, it is hard to objectively know for sure beforehand if the opportunity crossing your path is actually ‘amazing’. The litmus test for most new opportunities is the cost-benefit analysis, where the benefit side entails assessing the upside potential of the opportunity. If a new opportunity has tremendous upside potential with few costs, then it is probably an ‘amazing’ opportunity (to use Branson’s words).

For most of us, pursuing new opportunities does not come naturally. In fact, our natural inclination may be to shy away from new opportunities, especially when things are already comfortable in our life. The history of the world is full of people who declined to pursue new opportunities, preferring the status quo. My message here is that, no matter what stage of your career you are in, always seek new opportunities. It is only by constantly looking for new opportunities that you can make a difference in the world.

In Closing

Some Last Words

As you read this book, I hope it comes through that I place the responsibility of success squarely on the shoulders of the individual. I see each person as a sculptor of his or her own life. For those who want to succeed or make a difference in this world, I am asking them to take charge and do certain things (the 'seven steps' outlined here) in their lives that will increase the odds of them achieving their goals and aspirations. My approach does not under-estimate the role of 'luck' in life, which many believe is a powerful force. Unfortunately, there is not much we can do as individuals to influence luck. There is no reason why any of us is destined to have less luck than others. If it is true that "luck dances with those already on the dance floor", I hope this book will help get you positioned well on the dance floor.

The Talk That Started It All

Every year millions of new graduates join the workforce worldwide. China and India each gain more than five million graduates annually. Other countries add their own millions to the ranks of young college graduates every year. Unfortunately, for most of these young people, their dreams and aspirations go unfulfilled as they struggle to figure out how to achieve their goals and make a difference to the world.

I discuss seven simple things that young people- from east to west, from north to south (and every place in between)- can do to realize their dreams. Because I derive these seven lessons from following the life trajectories of successful men and women around the world, they probably apply universally equally well. So, here are the seven simple lessons I have learned that hopefully can be of value to everyone as they move ahead in life and career. First, if you want to make a difference, **start seeing the rising Sun**. It would not be an exaggeration to say that Steve Jobs and Tim Cook could not have been more different from each other. Jobs was larger-than-life, Cook is as low-key as a major technology CEO today can be. But one thing that Jobs and Cook share in common is that they are both early risers. Not only Jobs and Cook, but some very successful people roll out of bed early everyday (think Howard Schultz of Starbucks, Indra Nooyi of PepsiCo, former first lady Michelle Obama, and cine star Akshay Kumar). Waking up early is beneficial in many ways: It brings discipline to your everyday life, adds time to an otherwise hectic day, allows you to exercise before starting a generally sedentary workday, and provides the perfect opportunity for tasks where you want to focus without being

interrupted by emails and phones. Benjamin Franklin, a founding father of the United States, had this to say on the topic of getting up early: The mind must be fully made up that to rise early is a duty, wherever it is practical and safe; that the habit is attainable and possible and that a strong effort and a sustained one, must be made to overcome all obstacles in rising early.

Second, **always say positive things about others**. The unsaid part of this simple idea is never talk trash (or negative things) about people, even when you think no one is listening. Had Uber's former CEO Travis Kalanick heeded this simple advice, he would still be doing what he loves the most: managing a highly-successful ride-sharing company with a global footprint. But Kalanick is not alone in finding himself in a tight spot because of his tendency to trash talk about people. George Patton was widely considered among the best military generals America produced in the last century, but he was notorious for his ill-tempered bursts and uncensored speech. His inability to monitor his words and lash out at others caused him to be repeatedly superseded as former subordinates were promoted to become his superior officers. It is worth remembering that 'the words of the reckless pierce like swords, but the tongue of the wise brings healing'. One successful person that seems to truly believe that negative words can be dangerously poisonous is the Indian superstar (and BBC Actor of the Millennium) Amitabh Bachchan. Though Bachchan has now spent almost 50 years in the film world, most of it under the harsh light of the media, one would be hard-pressed to find even one instance of either Bachchan speaking negatively about someone or an individual who can reliably report hearing Bachchan use negative words about anyone.

Third, if you want to make a difference, **find a guide**. Have you ever considered what all mountain climbers who summit the Mount Everest have in common? As anyone who has ever tried to scale the highest peak in the world can attest, successful climbs to the top require a good Sherpa (remember, Edmund Hillary and Sherpa Tenzing?). The Sherpa is an invaluable guide up the mountain, understands mountain weather, and is familiar with local topography. No matter which profession you are in, you need people to guide you through the crevices and hills on the way. Jobs had Wozniak in the beginning of his career, Bill Gates considers Warren Buffet a father-figure, and Jamie Dimon (of JP Morgan) got to where he is because Sandy Weill mentored him. Most of us would benefit from not getting taken in by the 'self-made man' myth, the appealing, but erroneous, idea that one can succeed on their own without help from others. Those who chose not to find someone to counsel them will invariably find their progress and professional growth to be stunted.

Fourth, **be humble**! Think of a few people who you believe are regarded as truly great figures in history. You may be surprised that one attribute that distinguishes truly great historical figures from also-rans is humility. Even though success breeds hubris, it is humility that gets others to respect successful people. Fortunately, humility is something that can be learned and practiced.

Fifth, if you want to make a difference, **work on your resilience**. There is scarcely a successful person in history who did not have to deal with failure along the way. Consider, Abraham Lincoln, who persevered through an impressive list of setbacks before he won the presidency of the United States in 1860. For Lincoln,

and many others before and after, failure is a fantastic teacher from which they learn and improve. Those who are discouraged by setbacks and are unable to muster the will to persevere through them will find themselves get left behind.

Sixth, it is crucial that you ask yourself where your passion is, and then **do whatever it is that you are passionate about**. Passion has two parts to it: Do what you love, and love what you do. Lucky are those who are able to do what they love in life, so if you can make a career out of something you love, then by all means go for it. It is however also perfectly acceptable if you are able to love what you do. Problem arise when you are doing something that you neither love nor are able to love, because then there is little motivation to do it well.

Seventh, **always seek new opportunities**. One acts when one sees an opportunity upon which to act. Unfortunately, opportunities do not come labeled as such; they come labeled as work. When people see more work, they tend to turn away from it, which closes the opportunity for them. Donald Trump is a great example of someone who has relentlessly pursued new opportunities from the time he started his first venture. Whether it was dealing in real estate, running resorts and casinos, launching a reality show, introducing Trump-branded products, writing books, and even shooting for the highest office in the country, Trump has relentlessly chased new opportunities all his life. The result is obvious for all to see: The Trump brand is one of the most recognized corporate names in the United States.

In closing, get an early start each day. Speak only positively about other people, no matter how much the temptation to trash talk someone. Seek your own Sherpa(s) to help you climb the next peak in your life. Humility is the best

prescription for earning respect. Be resilient and not be discouraged by setbacks. Find what you are passionate about. Always look for the next opportunity, and even though it may seem like a lot of work, grab it with both hands. If you do these simple things, you will be in a much better position to realize your dreams and make a difference in the world.

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